to here – Japan, Korea and Vietnam – and even in these countries, it has been greatly modified by local values and traditions.

The country most impacted by Chinese cultural influence was Japan. In an earlier phase, from the fourth to the seventh centuries CE , Chinese culture, in particular Buddhism, was transmitted to Japan largely through Korea. This included, as we have seen, the Chinese language and script. However, from the seventh century onwards, there was direct Japanese engagement with China, through the travels of Chinese Buddhist monks to Japan; and through Japanese monks, traders and, more importantly, official diplomatic missions to China, known as the Kentoshi missions. The word ‘kentoshi’ literally means ‘envoy to the Tang’, but the first mission actually took place during the Sui dynasty, which preceded the Tang. There were as many as eighteen recorded Kentoshi missions between 600 CE and the last such mission in 838 CE . It is with one such Kentoshi mission that Bodhisena travelled to Japan from China.

The Kentoshi missions not only comprised royal envoys but also included Buddhist monks, scholars, craftsmen and merchants. They served as all-purpose study missions, aimed at wholesale cultural borrowing. Japan adopted its own version of the Chinese ‘Tianzi’ or ‘Son of Heaven’ depiction of the emperor, and the concept of ‘Tianxia’ or ‘Rule over All Under Heaven’. The emperor in Japan thus came to be known as ‘Tenno’, which in Chinese reads as ‘Tian Wang’ or ‘Heavenly King’. Several well-known Japanese monks and scholars travelled to China with such missions, carrying back to Japan Chinese translations of Buddhist scriptures, relic items, miniature shrines and innovative developments in Buddhist doctrines such as Chan, known in Japan as Zen. This scale of cultural borrowing is similar to the adoption of Western science and technology and even modes of formal dressing in Japan during the Meiji Restoration in the nineteenth century.

The Chinese-influenced East Asian sphere constituted a limited periphery and cannot support Chinese claims to ancient and enduring centrality. Japan never came under Chinese rule, and Vietnam became an independent political entity as early as in the eleventh century. There were several wars